Earning from a Lightning node

What a node can earn, what it needs, and an honest look at this one. Figures are examples to learn the arithmetic, not promises.

Start with the honest answer

> Today this node earns **by getting paid**, not by itself. It has one private channel, runs on a Mac that sleeps, uses Neutrino, and holds about 30,000 sats. Routing and leasing need public channels, an always-on machine and much more capital. The steps below show how to get there, one drill at a time.

1. Get paid for your own work (works now)

Every invoice altradits.com makes lands on your own node: proposals, tips, donations, trivia stakes. No middleman holds it, fees are a few sats, and settlement takes seconds. This is the main value of the node today, and it costs nothing extra.

2. Routing fees

When a payment passes through your node, you charge a base fee plus a rate in **ppm** (parts per million) of the amount.

```
fee = base_fee + amount x ppm / 1,000,000

Example: 100 payments a month of 50,000 sats, at 1 sat base + 500 ppm
per payment: 1 + 50,000 x 500 / 1,000,000 = 26 sats
per month:   2,600 sats (about $2)
```

Needs: public channels, balanced liquidity on both sides, 99%+ uptime, and well-chosen peers. **Reality:** small nodes often earn less than their channel-opening costs in the first year. **Track it:** `ln-ro fwdinghistory` and the Money tab's profit and loss.

3. Selling inbound liquidity (leases)

This is what Magma's seller did for you: you open a channel with *your* sats to a buyer for a fee and a set term. Marketplaces: Amboss Magma, Lightning Pool, or direct deals.

```
yield per year = fee / channel size x 365 / term_days

Example: 2,000,000-sat channel, 6,000-sat fee, 180-day term
6,000 / 2,000,000 x 365 / 180 = about 0.6% a year, before on-chain fees
```

Needs: on-chain capital you can lock up for months, money for on-chain fees to open (and later close), and a reachable, always-on node. **Risks:** fees can eat the yield, buyers may close early, and capital is stuck in the channel. **Track it:** the Earn tab's lease ledger and price quotes.

4. Services built on the node

Wallets and payment tools for others (like Yebente or kTown) can earn a spread or a fee, but they carry legal duties when you hold or move other people's money. Get the lawyer's answer first, as with the Yebente licence questions, and keep payment records.

5. Teaching what you practise

Every drill you repeat becomes material: tutorials like these, workshops, talks and guides for bootcamps and developers. This uses the node as a classroom rather than a business, and it is the earning path that fits your Bitcoin-learning site best.

What this node needs before 2 and 3 make sense

Need	Today	Next step
Always-on machine	A Mac that can sleep	A small dedicated computer or server that never sleeps
Public channels	One private channel	Open 1 to 3 public channels to well-connected nodes
Capital	About 30,000 sats spendable	Enough on-chain sats to open channels you can leave for months
Blockchain source	Neutrino	Fine to start. Your own Bitcoin Core (pruned) later
Records	Withdrawal record, lease ledger	Log every fee earned and paid, for tax

Before you earn: the rules

• Practise every step on regtest and signet first (see the practice plan).

• Never lock up money you might need soon: channel funds can take weeks to come back after a force close.

• Count on-chain fees as costs. A channel that earns 500 sats but cost 3,000 to open lost money.

• Keep records of income for tax, and ask before offering services to the public.